

The Whispering Woods

A D&D 5th Edition Mystery Adventure for Characters Level 1-3

Adventure Length: 3-4 sessions

Party Size: 3-5 characters

Adventure Type: Mystery / Investigation / Light Horror

Themes: Rural mystery, nature magic, community bonds, coming-of-age

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Adventure Background

The small farming village of Millbrook has always lived in harmony with the nearby Whispering Woods, a ancient forest known for its unusually intelligent wildlife and benevolent nature spirits. For generations, the village children have played safely among the trees, and the woods have provided herbs, game, and protection from bandits.

But something has changed. Over the past month, the woods have grown silent and strange. Animals have fled, the trees seem to watch with hostile intent, and eerie whispers carry on the wind even when no breeze stirs the leaves. Most troubling of all, three village children ventured into the woods five days ago and haven't returned.

The village elder, desperate for help, has sent word to any brave souls willing to investigate. The children's families grow more frantic by the hour, and some villagers whisper that the woods

themselves have turned against Millbrook. As night falls, strange lights flicker between the trees, and the whispers grow louder.

Central Mystery: A young druid named Lyra, barely sixteen and untrained in controlling her awakening powers, fled to the woods after accidentally causing a magical accident in the village. Her fear and shame have manifested as a powerful but unstable natural magic that's corrupting the forest's harmony. The missing children found her and are trying to help, but they're all trapped by Lyra's uncontrolled magic creating increasingly dangerous manifestations.

The Magical Disturbance

Lyra's emotional turmoil has created a feedback loop with the forest's natural magic:

- **Fear** manifests as aggressive plant growth and hostile animal behavior
- **Shame** creates illusions that hide the truth and misdirect investigators
- **Loneliness** calls out through the supernatural whispers heard throughout the area
- **Desperation** spawns minor elemental creatures that attack perceived threats

The longer Lyra remains in this state, the more permanent the corruption becomes. What started as a scared teenager's magical outburst is beginning to create a permanent blight on the forest that could spread to threaten the entire region.

The Village of Millbrook

Overview

Millbrook is a farming community of about 200 people situated in a fertile valley beside the Whispering Woods. The village consists of scattered farmsteads surrounding a central cluster of important buildings: the inn, the general store, the temple, and the elder's hall.

Key Features:

- **The Mill:** The village's namesake, powered by a stream flowing from the woods
- **The Green:** Central gathering place with a well and bulletin board
- **The Sheep's Rest Inn:** Two-story building serving as tavern and inn
- **Bronson's General Store:** Supplies and trade goods
- **Temple of Chauntea:** Small shrine tended by Sister Meredith
- **Elder Gareth's Hall:** Village meeting place and courthouse

Recent Changes

- **Harvest Disruption:** Crops nearest the woods are withering unexpectedly
- **Animal Behavior:** Livestock are skittish and refuse to graze near the forest

- **Strange Weather:** Localized fog and sudden temperature drops near the woods
- **Sleep Disturbances:** Villagers report nightmares and hearing whispers at night
- **Economic Impact:** Traders are avoiding the village due to the "cursed" reputation

Village Atmosphere

The normally cheerful community is tense with worry and fear. Neighbors eye each other suspiciously, wondering if someone brought a curse upon them. Parents keep their children close, and the usual evening gatherings have ceased. The missing children - Sara (age 12), Tom (age 10), and little Emmy (age 8) - are beloved by the entire community.

Adventure Hooks

The Desperate Plea

The party encounters Elder Gareth on the road or receives his letter requesting help. He offers the village's meager savings (50 gold pieces) and promises of future favor for anyone who can find the missing children and end the woods' corruption.

Personal Connections

One of the party members has ties to Millbrook:

- **Family Relations:** A character's cousin, aunt, or grandparent lives in the village
- **Childhood Home:** A character grew up here before leaving for adventure
- **Business Interests:** A character's family has trade connections with the village
- **Religious Duty:** A cleric or paladin is responding to Sister Meredith's prayers

The Wandering Scholar

The party meets Tobias Quill, a traveling scholar researching forest magic, who's investigating reports of the supernatural disturbances. He offers to pay for assistance and share any magical knowledge discovered.

Accidental Involvement

The party was simply passing through when they witnessed strange lights in the woods or heard the supernatural whispers. Their investigation leads them to discover the missing children situation.

The Guilt-Driven Relative

Lyra's older brother Marcus approaches the party secretly, suspecting his sister might be involved but unable to search for her himself due to his responsibilities caring for their sick mother.

The Mystery Unfolds

Day 1: Arrival and Initial Investigation

The Village's Story: According to the villagers, the trouble began about a month ago when the woods "went quiet." The missing children were last seen heading toward their favorite playing spot near the Old Oak five days ago.

Initial Clues:

- **The Children's Route:** Tracks lead from the village toward the deeper woods
- **Magical Residue:** Detect Magic reveals unusual auras near the forest edge
- **Witness Accounts:** Some villagers report seeing "dancing lights" at night
- **Emotional Testimony:** Parents describe their children's recent strange behavior

Investigation Opportunities:

- **Interview villagers** about recent events and the missing children
- **Examine the forest edge** for clues about what drove away the wildlife
- **Research local lore** about the woods' history and any past incidents
- **Investigate the children's belongings** left behind in their homes

Day 2: Into the Woods

Environmental Changes: As the party enters the Whispering Woods, they immediately notice the supernatural alterations:

- **Unnatural Silence:** No bird songs, insect buzzing, or small animal noises
- **Hostile Flora:** Plants seem to lean away from paths or block passage
- **Temperature Drops:** Cold spots appear randomly, especially near water
- **The Whispers:** Indistinct voices speaking in Sylvan, saying fragments like "help me," "I'm sorry," and "don't leave me alone"

Navigation Challenges: The corrupted magic makes the usually familiar paths confusing:

- **Misleading Trails:** Paths that should lead to known locations become circular
- **Illusion Effects:** Familiar landmarks appear in wrong locations
- **Magical Interference:** Compasses spin wildly, and survival skills are hindered
- **Emotional Manipulation:** Characters may feel sudden waves of fear, sadness, or guilt

Day 3: Deeper Mysteries

Escalating Encounters: As the party ventures deeper, the magical disturbances become more active and dangerous:

- **Animated Plants:** Vines and branches that attack when approached
- **Minor Elementals:** Small earth and water elementals spawned by Lyra's emotions
- **Illusory Dangers:** False threats that seem real but vanish when struck
- **Protective Barriers:** Magical walls that seem to guard specific areas

The Children's Trail: Persistent investigation reveals signs of the missing children:

- **Recent Campsites:** Evidence of the children sheltering in various locations
 - **Food Caches:** Hidden supplies suggesting they're surviving but hiding
 - **Messages:** Simple symbols carved in bark that the children use to communicate
 - **Protective Circles:** Areas where someone has attempted to ward off the magical effects
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Key Locations

1. The Forest Edge - The Barrier of Fear

Where the village farmland meets the Whispering Woods, an invisible line marks the beginning of the supernatural disturbance. Crops wither within fifty feet of the tree line, and a palpable sense of unease fills the air.

Environmental Features:

- **Dying Vegetation:** Plants show signs of blight and magical corruption
- **Animal Remains:** Bones of small creatures that fled too late
- **Magical Aura:** Detect Magic reveals transmutation and enchantment effects
- **Emotional Resonance:** Empathic characters feel waves of fear and sadness

Encounters:

- **Hostile Wildlife:** 2-3 wolves driven to aggression by the magical corruption
- **Animated Shrubs:** 1d4 awakened shrubs that attack intruders
- **Investigation Opportunity:** Finding the children's initial tracks (Survival DC 12)

Treasure:

- Child's wooden toy (Sara's carved horse)
- Scattered coins from torn pocket (3 copper pieces)

2. The Whispering Creek - The Voice of Sorrow

A normally cheerful stream that provided fresh water for village activities now runs dark and cold. The water itself seems to murmur with voices, and strange reflections appear on its surface.

Environmental Features:

- **Contaminated Water:** Safe to drink but tastes of salt (tears)
- **Auditory Illusions:** The water carries fragments of speech in Sylvan
- **False Reflections:** The stream shows images of the missing children
- **Crossing Challenges:** The water has become unusually deep and cold

Encounters:

- **Water Weird:** A manifestation of Lyra's grief controlling the stream
- **Emotional Challenge:** Characters must resist despair (Wisdom save DC 13)
- **Hidden Message:** Tom's initials carved in a riverside stone

Clues:

- Children's footprints on both sides suggest they crossed here multiple times
- A small dam made of stones shows recent construction
- Wilted flowers along the bank match ones from the village temple

3. The Twisted Grove - The Maze of Guilt

Once a perfect circle of ancient oaks where villagers held seasonal celebrations, this grove now forms a confusing labyrinth. The trees have grown together in impossible ways, creating a maze that defies normal navigation.

Environmental Features:

- **Spatial Distortion:** The grove is larger on the inside than outside
- **Shifting Passages:** Paths change when characters aren't looking
- **Guilt Manifestation:** Characters experience memories of past mistakes
- **Time Displacement:** Hours may pass while feeling like minutes

Encounters:

- **Twig Blights:** 1d6+2 animated by Lyra's self-reproach
- **Maze Navigation:** Intelligence (Investigation) DC 15 to find the center
- **Memory Traps:** Relive embarrassing or shameful moments (Charisma save DC 12)

Treasure:

- **The Children's Camp:** Hidden in the grove's center, with evidence of recent habitation

- Emmy's doll, carefully tended and showing signs of magical protection
- Crude map drawn by the children showing safe paths through the woods

4. The Heartwood Clearing - The Eye of the Storm

At the forest's heart lies a circular clearing dominated by an enormous ancient oak. This tree, older than the village itself, serves as the focal point for all the forest's magic. Now it pulses with chaotic energy as wild magic swirls around its massive trunk.

Environmental Features:

- **Magical Epicenter:** All effects are strongest here
- **Reality Fluctuations:** Magic behaves unpredictably in this area
- **Emotional Intensity:** The source of all the supernatural manifestations
- **Natural Sanctuary:** Despite the chaos, this area feels sacred and protected

The Revelation: Here the party finds Lyra and the three missing children. Lyra, exhausted and frightened, has been trying to control magic far beyond her current abilities. The children discovered her here and have been bringing her food and comfort, but their kindness has only made her feel worse about the trouble she's caused.

The Confrontation: This isn't a combat encounter but a social and emotional challenge. Lyra is terrified that the party has come to punish her for the destruction she's caused. The children are protective of their new friend but also desperately want to go home.

NPCs and Inhabitants

Village NPCs

Elder Gareth Millbrook *Male human, age 65, lawful good* The village founder's great-grandson and current leader. A practical man who's lived through good times and bad, but nothing quite like this supernatural crisis.

Personality: Stoic, caring, feels responsible for everyone's safety **Goal:** Resolve the crisis and bring the children home safely **Information:** Knows the forest's history and can provide background on local magic **Roleplaying:** Speaks slowly and carefully, worried about saying the wrong thing

Sister Meredith *Female human, age 40, neutral good* The village's spiritual leader and healer, she tends a small shrine to Chauntea and provides medical care to the community.

Personality: Compassionate, wise, sees the good in everyone **Goal:** Help Lyra learn to control her abilities safely **Information:** Recognizes the signs of awakening druidic magic **Roleplaying:** Gentle voice, always looking for peaceful solutions

Marcus Reed *Male human, age 19, chaotic good* Lyra's older brother, torn between loyalty to his sister and responsibility to the village. He suspects Lyra might be involved but hasn't told anyone.

Personality: Protective, conflicted, mature beyond his years **Goal:** Help his sister without betraying the village's trust **Secret:** Has been leaving food at the forest edge, hoping Lyra will find it **Roleplaying:** Nervous energy, quick to defend his family's reputation

Elena Brightwater *Female human, age 35, neutral good* Sara's mother and the village's best tracker. She's been leading search parties but hasn't been able to enter the corrupted forest.

Personality: Determined, fierce when protecting children, skilled outdoorswoman **Goal:** Find her daughter and the other children at any cost **Information:** Knows the children's favorite places in the woods **Roleplaying:** Intense focus, speaks quickly when discussing the children

Forest Inhabitants

Lyra Reed *Female human, age 16, neutral good* A young druid whose powers awakened traumatically when she accidentally caused a barn fire while trying to help with the harvest. Overwhelmed by guilt and fear, she fled to the forest where her uncontrolled emotions are corrupting the natural magic.

Personality: Frightened, guilty, kind-hearted but overwhelmed **Goal:** Stop causing harm, but doesn't know how to control her abilities **Powers:** Uncontrolled druidic magic that responds to her emotions **Roleplaying:** Speaks in whispers, flinches at sudden movements, cries easily

Sara Brightwater *Female human, age 12, neutral good* The natural leader among the missing children, she convinced Tom and Emmy to help the "sad forest girl" instead of returning home immediately.

Personality: Brave, caring, natural leader **Goal:** Help Lyra while keeping everyone safe **Abilities:** Good at finding food and shelter, natural empathy **Roleplaying:** Protective of younger children, speaks with surprising maturity

Tom Miller *Male human, age 10, chaotic good* The miller's son, adventurous and curious. He discovered Lyra first and has been the most helpful in gathering supplies.

Personality: Curious, brave, sometimes impulsive **Goal:** Help Lyra learn to control her magic so everyone can be friends **Abilities:** Excellent climber, knows hidden paths through the woods **Roleplaying:** Enthusiastic, interrupts others with ideas

Emmy Thorne *Female human, age 8, neutral good* The youngest of the missing children, she's been the most comforting presence for Lyra and has a natural affinity for magic.

Personality: Sweet, innocent, surprisingly wise for her age **Goal:** Make everyone happy and safe
Special: Has latent magical sensitivity that responds to Lyra's power **Roleplaying:** Speaks simply but often says unexpectedly profound things

The Forest Spirit

Oakenheart *Genderless fey, ancient, neutral* The guardian spirit of the Whispering Woods, weakened by the magical corruption but still conscious. It appears as shifting patterns of light and shadow among the trees.

Personality: Patient, wise, concerned about the forest's health **Goal:** Restore natural balance while protecting all innocent lives **Information:** Understands what's happening and wants to help resolve it peacefully **Communication:** Speaks through rustling leaves, changing light patterns, and empathic impressions

Investigation Paths

Path 1: Following the Children

Starting Point: Interviewing the children's families and examining their belongings **Clues Lead To:**

- Favorite playing spots in the forest
- Hidden supply caches the children created
- Messages left in their secret code
- Evidence of their daily routine while missing

Key Skills: Survival, Investigation, Insight **Challenges:** Corrupted trails, false tracks created by magic, dangerous areas **Revelation:** The children are alive and helping someone in need

Path 2: Understanding the Magic

Starting Point: Detecting magical auras and researching local lore **Clues Lead To:**

- The source of the corruption at the Heartwood Clearing
- Signs of uncontrolled druidic magic
- Evidence of emotional-based spell manifestation
- Ancient texts about awakening magical abilities

Key Skills: Arcana, History, Religion, Nature **Challenges:** Magical interference, incomplete records, supernatural guardians **Revelation:** A young druid's awakening powers are causing the disturbance

Path 3: Village Secrets

Starting Point: Deep conversations with villagers about recent events **Clues Lead To:**

- The Reed family's recent troubles
- Lyra's disappearance coinciding with the forest's corruption
- Marcus's suspicious behavior and secret food trips
- The barn fire incident that preceded everything

Key Skills: Persuasion, Insight, Deception, Intimidation **Challenges:** Villagers' reluctance to gossip, family loyalty, fear of blame **Revelation:** Lyra is the missing piece connecting all the strange events

Path 4: Communing with Nature

Starting Point: Attempting to communicate with forest spirits or animals **Clues Lead To:**

- The forest spirit Oakenheart's attempts to communicate
- Remaining wildlife fleeing toward specific safe areas
- Plants and trees trying to guide helpful visitors
- Natural magic responding to genuine care and empathy

Key Skills: Animal Handling, Nature, Survival, Religion **Challenges:** Corrupted natural communication, aggressive magical manifestations **Revelation:** The forest itself wants to help but is being overwhelmed by uncontrolled magic

The Truth Revealed

Lyra's Story

A month ago, during harvest time, Lyra was trying to help her family by using her newly awakened druidic abilities to encourage crop growth. However, her inexperience and emotional stress caused the magic to manifest as intense heat instead of gentle growth magic. The result was a barn fire that destroyed a significant portion of the village's stored grain.

Overcome with guilt and terrified of her uncontrollable powers, Lyra fled to the Whispering Woods where she felt safest. However, her emotional turmoil continued to manifest as wild magic, gradually corrupting the forest's natural harmony.

The Children's Kindness

Five days ago, the three children discovered Lyra while playing in their favorite spot near the Old Oak. Instead of being frightened, they recognized her distress and decided to help. Sara took charge of bringing food, Tom found safe shelters, and Emmy provided emotional comfort.

Their kindness has been both a blessing and a curse for Lyra - while their friendship has kept her from complete despair, their presence has also made her more determined to stay hidden rather than return and face the consequences of the barn fire.

The Resolution Challenge

The party must convince Lyra that:

1. The village isn't angry with her - they're worried and want to help
2. Her powers can be controlled with proper training and support
3. The forest's corruption will only worsen if she doesn't act
4. The children need to return home to their worried families
5. There are people who can teach her to use her abilities safely

This requires a combination of:

- **Successful social encounters** to gain Lyra's trust
 - **Demonstration of magical knowledge** to prove they understand her situation
 - **Emotional support** to help her overcome her guilt and fear
 - **Practical solutions** like introducing her to Sister Meredith or other druids
 - **Community acceptance** arranged through conversations with village leaders
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Encounters and Challenges

Low-Level Combat Encounters

Corrupted Wolf *Medium beast, chaotic neutral*

- **Armor Class** 13 (Natural Armor)
- **Hit Points** 11 (2d8 + 2)
- **Speed** 40 ft.
- **STR** 12 (+1) **DEX** 15 (+2) **CON** 12 (+1) **INT** 3 (-4) **WIS** 12 (+1) **CHA** 6 (-2)
- **Skills** Perception +3, Stealth +4
- **Senses** passive Perception 13
- **Languages** —
- **Challenge** 1/4 (50 XP)

Keen Hearing and Smell. The wolf has advantage on Wisdom (Perception) checks that rely on hearing or smell.

Pack Tactics. The wolf has advantage on an attack roll against a creature if at least one of the wolf's allies is within 5 feet of the creature and the ally isn't incapacitated.

Magical Corruption. The wolf's behavior is erratic due to magical influence. It retreats if reduced to half hit points, showing remnants of its natural temperament.

Actions Bite. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +4 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 7 (2d4 + 2) piercing damage. If the target is a creature, it must succeed on a DC 11 Strength saving throw or be knocked prone.

Encounter: 2-3 Corrupted Wolves **Tactics:** Surround and harass rather than fight to the death

Resolution: Can be calmed with Animal Handling DC 15 or magical intervention

Awakened Shrub *Small plant, unaligned*

- **Armor Class** 9
- **Hit Points** 10 (3d6)
- **Speed** 20 ft.
- **STR** 3 (-4) **DEX** 8 (-1) **CON** 11 (+0) **INT** 10 (+0) **WIS** 10 (+0) **CHA** 6 (-2)
- **Damage Vulnerabilities** fire
- **Damage Resistances** piercing
- **Senses** passive Perception 10
- **Languages** one language known by its creator
- **Challenge** 0 (10 XP)

False Appearance. While the shrub remains motionless, it is indistinguishable from a normal shrub.

Emotional Resonance. The shrub is animated by Lyra's distress and becomes docile if her emotions are calmed.

Actions Rake. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +1 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 1 (1d4 - 1) slashing damage.

Encounter: 1d4+2 Awakened Shrubs **Tactics:** Block paths and entangle rather than cause serious harm **Resolution:** Become docile if Lyra's emotions are calmed or if approached peacefully

Twig Blight *Small plant, neutral evil*

- **Armor Class** 13 (Natural Armor)
- **Hit Points** 4 (1d6 + 1)

- **Speed** 20 ft.
- **STR** 6 (-2) **DEX** 13 (+1) **CON** 12 (+1) **INT** 4 (-3) **WIS** 8 (-1) **CHA** 3 (-4)
- **Skills** Stealth +3
- **Damage Vulnerabilities** fire
- **Condition Immunities** blinded, deafened
- **Senses** blindsight 60 ft. (blind beyond this radius), passive Perception 9
- **Languages** understands Common but can't speak
- **Challenge** 1/8 (25 XP)

False Appearance. While the blight remains motionless, it is indistinguishable from a dead shrub.

Corruption Regeneration. While in the magically corrupted area, the blight regains 1 hit point at the start of its turn if it has at least 1 hit point.

Actions Claws. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +3 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 3 (1d4 + 1) piercing damage.

Encounter: 1d6+2 Twig Blights **Tactics:** Swarm tactics, focusing on isolated characters

Resolution: Destroyed permanently only when the corruption is cleansed

Minor Water Elemental *Small elemental, neutral*

- **Armor Class** 14 (Natural Armor)
- **Hit Points** 27 (5d6 + 10)
- **Speed** 30 ft., swim 90 ft.
- **STR** 14 (+2) **DEX** 14 (+2) **CON** 15 (+2) **INT** 4 (-3) **WIS** 10 (+0) **CHA** 8 (-1)
- **Damage Resistances** acid; bludgeoning, piercing, and slashing from nonmagical attacks
- **Damage Immunities** poison
- **Condition Immunities** exhaustion, grappled, paralyzed, petrified, poisoned, prone, restrained, unconscious
- **Senses** darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 10
- **Languages** Aquan
- **Challenge** 1/2 (100 XP)

Water Form. The elemental can enter a hostile creature's space and stop there. It can move through a space as narrow as 1 inch wide without squeezing.

Freeze. If the elemental takes cold damage, it partially freezes; its speed is reduced by 20 feet until the end of its next turn.

Emotional Origin. Formed from Lyra's tears and magical distress. Disperses harmlessly when her emotional state improves.

Actions *Slam.* *Melee Weapon Attack:* +4 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 5 (1d6 + 2) bludgeoning damage.

Whelm (Recharge 4-6). Each creature in the elemental's space must make a DC 13 Strength saving throw. On a failure, a target takes 5 (1d6 + 2) bludgeoning damage. If it is Medium or smaller, it is also grappled (escape DC 12). Until this grapple ends, the target is restrained and unable to breathe unless it can breathe water.

Encounter: 1 Minor Water Elemental **Tactics:** Grapples and attempts to drag characters into deep water **Resolution:** Only fights near water sources, retreats if taken far from stream

Water Weird *Large monstrosity, neutral*

- **Armor Class** 13
- **Hit Points** 58 (9d10 + 9)
- **Speed** 0 ft., swim 60 ft.
- **STR** 17 (+3) **DEX** 16 (+3) **CON** 13 (+1) **INT** 11 (+0) **WIS** 10 (+0) **CHA** 10 (+0)
- **Damage Resistances** fire; bludgeoning, piercing, and slashing from nonmagical attacks
- **Damage Immunities** poison
- **Condition Immunities** exhaustion, grappled, paralyzed, poisoned, prone, restrained, unconscious
- **Senses** blindsight 60 ft., passive Perception 10
- **Languages** understands Common and Aquan but can't speak
- **Challenge** 3 (700 XP)

Invisible in Water. The water weird is invisible while fully immersed in water.

Water Bound. The water weird dies if it leaves the water to which it is bound or if that water is destroyed.

Grief Manifestation. This water weird is a manifestation of Lyra's sorrow controlling the corrupted stream.

Actions *Constrict.* *Melee Weapon Attack:* +5 to hit, reach 10 ft., one creature. *Hit:* 13 (3d6 + 3) bludgeoning damage. If the target is Medium or smaller, it is grappled (escape DC 13) and pulled 5 feet toward the water weird. Until this grapple ends, the target is restrained, the water weird tries to drown it, and the water weird can't constrict another target.

Drown. The water weird attempts to drown a grappled creature. The target must make a DC 13 Constitution saving throw. On a failed save, the target runs out of breath and begins suffocating. On a successful save, the target is no longer grappled and moves to the nearest unoccupied space.

Encounter: 1 Water Weird (at the Whispering Creek) **Tactics:** Attempts to grapple and drown threats to maintain control of the water **Resolution:** Can be reasoned with if characters understand its connection to Lyra's grief

Lyra's Emotional Outburst (Potential Combat if Approached Aggressively) *When cornered or threatened, Lyra's uncontrolled magic manifests as a defensive reaction*

Lyra Reed (Panicked State) *Medium humanoid (human), neutral good*

- **Armor Class** 11 (Natural Armor from bark-like skin)
- **Hit Points** 22 (4d8 + 4)
- **Speed** 30 ft.
- **STR** 8 (-1) **DEX** 12 (+1) **CON** 13 (+1) **INT** 12 (+1) **WIS** 16 (+3) **CHA** 8 (-1)
- **Skills** Animal Handling +5, Medicine +5, Nature +5, Perception +5
- **Senses** passive Perception 15
- **Languages** Common, Druidic
- **Challenge** 1 (200 XP)

Uncontrolled Magic. Lyra's emotional state causes unpredictable magical effects. When she takes damage, roll a d4:

1. *Entangle* spell centered on her (DC 13)
2. *Faerie Fire* affects all creatures within 20 feet (DC 13)
3. Summons 1d4 awakened shrubs to defend her
4. *Fog Cloud* obscures the area for 1 minute

Spellcasting. Lyra is a 2nd-level spellcaster. Her spellcasting ability is Wisdom (spell save DC 13, +5 to hit with spell attacks). She has the following druid spells prepared:

- **Cantrips (at will):** *druidcraft, guidance, produce flame*
- **1st level (3 slots):** *cure wounds, entangle, faerie fire*

Pacifist Nature. Lyra does not want to fight and will only use defensive spells or attempt to flee. She can be calmed with successful Persuasion (DC 15) or by demonstrating peaceful intent.

Actions **Produce Flame.** *Ranged Spell Attack:* +5 to hit, range 30 ft., one target. *Hit:* 4 (1d8) fire damage. (Only used if she has no other choice)

Entangle (1st Level Spell). Grasping weeds and vines sprout from the ground in a 20-foot square starting from a point within range. The area becomes difficult terrain for the duration. A creature in the area when the spell is cast must succeed on a DC 13 Strength saving throw or be restrained by the entangling plants until the spell ends.

Important Note: This encounter should only occur if the party approaches Lyra with hostility or threats. The preferred resolution is through peaceful negotiation, empathy, and understanding. Combat with Lyra represents a failure of the adventure's central themes and should result in negative consequences even if the party "wins."

Forest Guardian Spirits (Defensive Encounter) *If the party acts destructively in the forest, the remaining protective spirits may intervene*

Dryad Guardian *Medium fey, neutral*

- **Armor Class** 11 (16 with *barkskin*)
- **Hit Points** 22 (5d8)
- **Speed** 30 ft.
- **STR** 10 (+0) **DEX** 12 (+1) **CON** 11 (+0) **INT** 14 (+2) **WIS** 15 (+2) **CHA** 18 (+4)
- **Skills** Perception +4, Stealth +5
- **Senses** darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 14
- **Languages** Elvish, Sylvan
- **Challenge** 1 (200 XP)

Magic Resistance. The dryad has advantage on saving throws against spells and other magical effects.

Speak with Beasts and Plants. The dryad can communicate with beasts and plants as if they shared a language.

Tree Stride. Once on her turn, the dryad can use 10 feet of her movement to step magically into one living tree within her reach and emerge from a second living tree within 60 feet of the first tree, appearing in an unoccupied space within 5 feet of the second tree. Both trees must be Large or bigger.

Spellcasting. The dryad's spellcasting ability is Charisma (spell save DC 14). The dryad can cast the following spells, requiring no material components:

- **At will:** *druidcraft*
- **3/day each:** *entangle*, *goodberry*
- **1/day each:** *barkskin*, *pass without trace*, *shillelagh*

Actions **Club.** *Melee Weapon Attack:* +2 to hit (+6 to hit with *shillelagh*), reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 2 (1d4) bludgeoning damage, or 8 (1d8 + 4) bludgeoning damage with *shillelagh*.

Fey Charm. The dryad targets one humanoid or beast that she can see within 30 feet of her. If the target can see the dryad, it must succeed on a DC 14 Wisdom saving throw or be magically charmed. The charmed creature regards the dryad as a trusted friend to be heeded and protected. This effect lasts 24 hours or until the dryad dies.

Encounter: 1 Dryad Guardian (only if party is destructive) **Resolution:** Prefers to charm aggressors into being peaceful rather than fighting to the death

Environmental Challenges

The Maze of Guilt (Challenge Rating: 1) Navigate the Twisted Grove while resisting emotional manipulation

- **Challenge:** Intelligence (Investigation) DC 15 to find the correct path
- **Complication:** Wisdom saves DC 12 to resist being overwhelmed by guilt
- **Failure:** Become lost for 1d4 hours, possible encounter with twig blights
- **Success:** Find the children's camp and valuable clues

Crossing the Whispering Creek (Challenge Rating: 1/2) The corrupted stream has become treacherous and emotionally overwhelming

- **Challenge:** Dexterity (Athletics) DC 13 to cross safely
- **Complication:** Wisdom save DC 13 to resist despair from the voices
- **Failure:** Risk drowning or becoming overwhelmed with sadness
- **Success:** Safe crossing and potential communication with water elemental

Navigating Emotional Resonance (Challenge Rating: Variable) Resist the supernatural effects of Lyra's uncontrolled magic

- **Challenge:** Wisdom saves with DCs ranging from 10-15
- **Effects:** Fear, sadness, guilt, or confusion lasting 1d4 rounds
- **Mitigation:** Understanding the source provides advantage on saves
- **Benefit:** Success allows clearer thinking and better investigation

Social Encounters

Gaining Villagers' Trust (Challenge Rating: 1) Convince worried and suspicious villagers to share information

- **Challenge:** Persuasion or Insight checks DC 12-15
- **Complication:** Some villagers blame outsiders for the trouble
- **Failure:** Limited information, possible suspicion or hostility
- **Success:** Valuable clues, local support, access to resources

Calming Lyra's Fear (Challenge Rating: 2) Help a terrified young druid overcome her guilt and panic

- **Challenge:** Multiple approaches possible (Persuasion, Insight, Medicine, Arcana)
- **Complication:** Initial fear and self-blame make her resistant to help
- **Failure:** Magical outbursts become more dangerous
- **Success:** Essential for resolving the adventure peacefully

Mediating Between Factions (Challenge Rating: 1) Help villagers and Lyra find a path toward reconciliation

- **Challenge:** Persuasion and Insight checks to find common ground
 - **Complication:** Both sides have legitimate concerns and hurt feelings
 - **Failure:** Temporary solution that may not last
 - **Success:** Sustainable resolution that helps everyone involved
-

Treasure and Rewards

Monetary Rewards

- **Village Payment:** 50 gold pieces from Elder Gareth as promised
- **Individual Gratitude:** Small gifts from grateful families (10-25 gp value each)
- **Found Supplies:** Abandoned camping gear and tools worth 20-30 gp
- **Scholar's Payment:** Additional 25 gp if working with Tobias Quill

Magical Items (Minor)

Acorn of Forest's Blessing *Wondrous item, uncommon* A gift from Oakenheart, the forest spirit, this acorn glows with soft green light.

- **Property:** Once per day, can cast *Goodberry* without using a spell slot
- **Special:** The berries created taste exceptionally good and provide comfort as well as nourishment
- **Lore:** A token of the forest's gratitude and ongoing friendship

Child's Friendship Bracelet *Wondrous item, common* A simple bracelet of braided grass and flowers made by Emmy.

- **Property:** Provides advantage on Animal Handling checks with woodland creatures
- **Special:** Never wilts or breaks while worn with good intentions
- **Lore:** Represents the innocent trust and friendship that helped resolve the crisis

Lyra's Pressed Flower *Wondrous item, common* A perfectly preserved flower given as a token of thanks and remembrance.

- **Property:** Once per day, can be used to cast *Druidcraft* even by non-druids
- **Special:** Changes color to reflect the holder's emotional state
- **Lore:** A reminder that magic should serve life and growth, not destruction

Experience and Growth Rewards

Story Milestones:

- Discovering the truth about the children's disappearance: 100 XP per character
- Successfully communicating with Lyra: 150 XP per character
- Resolving the crisis without violence: 200 XP per character
- Helping establish ongoing support for Lyra: 100 XP per character

Investigation Successes:

- Following each investigation path to completion: 50 XP per character per path
- Uncovering the barn fire incident: 75 XP per character
- Understanding the magical corruption's source: 75 XP per character

Social Achievements:

- Gaining the trust of suspicious villagers: 25 XP per character
- Mediating between conflicting viewpoints: 50 XP per character
- Creating lasting solutions rather than temporary fixes: 100 XP per character

Long-Term Benefits

Village Connections:

- **Safe Haven:** Millbrook becomes a reliable place to rest and resupply
- **Information Network:** Villagers share news from travelers and traders
- **Support Network:** Help available during future emergencies or adventures
- **Reputation:** Word spreads of the party's kindness and competence

Lyra's Friendship:

- **Druidic Contact:** Access to nature magic assistance and forest lore
- **Growing Power:** As Lyra trains, she becomes a more capable ally
- **Network Access:** Introduction to other druids and natural magic users
- **Moral Support:** Someone who believes in resolving conflicts peacefully

Forest Guardian Blessing:

- **Safe Passage:** Oakenheart ensures safe travel through the Whispering Woods
- **Natural Allies:** Woodland creatures are more likely to be helpful
- **Environmental Awareness:** Advance warning of natural disasters or threats
- **Spiritual Growth:** Understanding of the balance between civilization and nature

Appendices

Appendix A: Scaling for Different Levels

For 1st Level Characters:

- Reduce combat encounters by one creature each
- Lower DCs by 2 for most challenges
- Provide more obvious clues and guidance
- Focus heavily on roleplay and investigation over combat
- Offer more healing resources in the village

For 3rd Level Characters:

- Add one additional creature to combat encounters
- Include a few 2nd-level spell effects in the magical corruption
- Raise social encounter DCs by 1-2
- Add complexity to the emotional resolution requirements
- Consider additional environmental hazards

Appendix B: Alternative Adventure Hooks

The Traveling Carnival: The party arrives with a small carnival troupe planning to perform in Millbrook, only to find the village in crisis.

The Lost Merchant: A trader the party is escorting has business in Millbrook, leading to discovery of the situation.

The Concerned Relative: A distant relative of one of the missing children hires the party to investigate when official searches fail.

The Academic Interest: A scholar studying magical awakening phenomena pays the party to investigate reports of wild magic in the area.

The Divine Vision: A cleric or paladin receives dreams or visions directing them to help a child in need in a forest village.

Appendix C: Extended Consequences

If the Adventure Succeeds Peacefully:

- Lyra receives training from Sister Meredith and visiting druids
- The village establishes a small shrine to nature spirits
- Trade relationships improve as the "curse" reputation fades
- The children become local heroes and develop confidence
- Millbrook becomes known for its acceptance of magical individuals

If the Adventure Involves Violence:

- Lyra's trauma deepens, requiring more extensive help
- The forest takes longer to heal from the magical corruption
- Village relationships with magic-users become strained
- Some corruption may remain, causing ongoing minor problems
- The children lose some of their innocent trust in adults

Future Adventure Opportunities:

- Lyra's training reveals larger threats to the natural world
- Other young magic-users seek help after hearing of Millbrook's success
- The village becomes a target for those who oppose magical acceptance
- Ancient forest secrets are revealed through the strengthened connection
- Regional druids ask for help with similar magical crises

Appendix D: NPC Relationship Dynamics

Family Relationships:

- Lyra and Marcus have a close but strained sibling bond
- The missing children's families are supportive but worried
- Village families generally trust each other but fear outside threats

Community Dynamics:

- Elder Gareth is respected but not feared by villagers
- Sister Meredith serves as both spiritual guide and practical counselor
- The village operates more by consensus than authority

Potential Conflicts:

- Some villagers may blame the Reed family for the crisis
- Fear of magic could create lasting divisions
- Economic losses from the supernatural events create tension
- Different ideas about how to help Lyra could cause disagreements

Designer's Notes

This adventure is designed to introduce newer players to investigation, social interaction, and moral complexity while maintaining the heroic fantasy elements that make D&D appealing. The focus on children in danger provides clear motivation, while the non-violent resolution encourages creative thinking over combat solutions.

The mystery structure allows for multiple valid approaches while ensuring that patient investigation and empathetic roleplay are rewarded. The supernatural elements provide fantasy

excitement without overwhelming low-level characters, and the emotional core of the story creates memorable moments that players will reference in future campaigns.

Estimated Play Time: 3-4 sessions of 3-4 hours each **Party Composition:** Works well with any combination of classes, particularly benefits from characters with social or investigation skills

Difficulty: Easy to moderate, with emphasis on problem-solving and roleplay over combat optimization

End of Adventure